

BOYS BASKETBALL

Dukes crush Falcons

Jerry Rombach
The Chronicle-Telegram

HENRIETTA — Wellington stood tall Tuesday night.

The Dukes' new-look starting lineup, featuring their tallest players, won 69-52 at Firelands in a Lorain County Conference game.

After Wellington (3-4 overall, 2-2 in the LCC) lost several close previous games, coach Tom Eibel decided on a new tactic against the favorite Falcons (4-3, 2-2).

"It came to me over the weekend that if we can't win with one team, try two teams," he said. "So I told the kids at practice yesterday that we're going to try something different with our taller players."

Dave Haswell (6-foot-4), Chris West (6-5) and Garrett Haldeman (5-10) started in place of previous starters Thomas Dulemba (5-9), Kevin Cook (6-0) and Brandon Fullen (6-1).

The plan worked to perfection, not only due to the tall zone defense it presented, but with some sizzling shooting.

The Dukes jumped out to a 21-4 lead.

Haldeman scored 10 points in the first quarter and finished with 16. He had never scored more than five points before in a varsity game. The other new starter, Haswell, tallied 14 while West added four.

The lead mounted to 21 points, 26-5, with 48 seconds left in the first quarter before Firelands finally settled down and outscored Wellington 47-43 the rest of the game.

But despite getting the better of the Dukes for most of the game, the Falcons never got closer than the final 17-point deficit.

Wellington hit a sensational 9 of 14 shots in the first quarter and was at 65 percent at halftime (15-of-23). It finished with at 58 percent to only 38 percent for Firelands.

While the Dukes hit a number of long-distance shots, sinking seven 3-pointers, a big reason for their high percentage was a number of layups set up by precise inside passing.

And the tall lineup also was a key to a 33-22 rebound edge.

"By gosh, look at that," Eibel said while taking a first glance at the scorebook after the game. "Haldeman had his first start and scores 16."

"Our first half was just about a perfect game. In fact, at halftime I was scared, asking myself, 'How can we keep this up?'"

"I figured Firelands would be pressing the second half so I started my small team because it has better ball handlers."

"Who do I start in the next game? This sort of created a monster. I guess we'll just have to wait and see, depending on our opponent. So it will be a game-by-game decision. The tall team doesn't handle the ball as well as the small team."

Wellington hosts Clearview on Friday, while Firelands goes to Avon.

WELLINGTON (69): Whitney 7-0-17, Haldeman 6-2-16, Haswell 7-0-14, Kidd 4-4-14, West 2-0-4, Fullen 1-0-2, Cook 1-0-2, Dulemba 0-0-0, Vance 0-0-0, Baker 0-0-0 Totals 28-6-69.

FIRELANDS (52): Bennett 5-3-17, Burdett 4-0-9, Lister 2-1-3, Schrader 2-1-3, Warner 2-0-4, Schultz 2-0-4, O'Keefe 1-0-3, Wegand 1-0-2, Dodd 0-0-0, Smith 0-0-0, Donelson 0-0-0, Bates 0-0-0 Totals 21-5-52.

Wellington 25 15 16 12 — 69
Firelands 7 14 17 14 — 52

Three-pointers: Wellington 7 (Whitney 3, Haldeman 2, Kidd 2), Firelands 5 (Bennett 2, Lister, Burdett, O'Keefe). Field goals: Wellington 28-45, Firelands 21-54. Free throws: Wellington 6-11, Firelands 5-8. Rebounds: Wellington 33 (Whitney 9, Haswell 6), Firelands 22 (Bennett 4, Lister 3, Burdett 3). Turnovers: Wellington 15, Firelands 10. Fouls: Wellington 8, Firelands 9. Junior varsity: Firelands, 65-35.

BOYS BASKETBALL

EC grabs 3rd place

LIMA — Elyria Catholic's girls set three meet records as they totaled 438 points to finish in third place at Saturday's Thunderbird Invitational at Lima Central Catholic High School.

EC freshman Paige Samek won the 50 freestyle in 26.20 seconds, breaking the previous record of 26.87.

Samek, Haley Flowers, Kelly O'Brien and Alanna Roark won the 200 freestyle relay in 1:50.78, eclipsing the previous record of 1:51.44.

Flowers, a junior, won the 100 backstroke in 1:09.36, breaking the previous record of 1:10.27.

Elyria Catholic's boys were second in their team standings with 346 points.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Falls flexes its SWC muscles

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

OLMSTED FALLS — When Olmsted Falls is playing as well as it possibly can, there are few teams in Northern Ohio that can beat the Bulldogs.

And when a rival doesn't bring its best effort to a game against Olmsted Falls, things can become ugly.

It got hideous for North Olmsted on Tuesday, as Falls sent the Eagles home with a 77-33 loss in Southwestern Conference action.

The Bulldogs passed the ball crisply, took mostly high-percentage shots and played a skin-tight man-to-man defense that caused the Eagles all sorts of problems trying to keep possession.

"We came to play," Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "This might be the best we've played this year as far as a complete game is concerned. Our pressure was outstanding and we were unselfish with the ball."

Olmsted Falls (6-1, 4-0 SWC) made 58 percent of its field goals (26 of 45) in the three quarters in which the starters played, while forcing North Olmsted (3-5, 1-3 SWC) into 20 turnovers to its six.

"Our intensity picked up," Donahue said. "We didn't come out intense. The score was 2-0 for a long time. But when things got rolling for us the intensity got rolling with it."

The score became 5-0 on a three-point play by Dan Binggeli at 5:03 of the first quarter. It grew to 10-0 a minute later. North Olmsted ended the shutout when Sean Troha hit a free throw at 3:26. The Eagles got their first field goal, by Jim Herold, at 3:01.

The score was 21-11 when things started snowballing for the Bulldogs. Olmsted Falls had a 20-point lead by halftime, with Steve Gansey leading the attack with 14 points and four assists.



LINDA MURPHY / CHRONICLE

"Their pressure had us so disoriented in the first half that we could not get into anything," North Olmsted coach Tim Schmotzer said. "Their pressure was tremendous and we could not handle it. We used poor judgment too often."

The Eagles committed eight turnovers in the first period and eight more in the third. Olmsted Falls closed the third quarter with a 12-2 run to open a 34-point lead.

"After a game like this you pick yourself up, move on and try to make something good

come from it," Schmotzer added. "We know what we have to do. We have to make Friday's game against Fairview a bigger game for us than it will be for Fairview."

Binggeli led Olmsted Falls with 19 points. Gansey finished his evening with 17 points and five assists. Jamar Scales chipped in with 14 points for the Bulldogs.

Chris Hibinger led the Eagles with nine points. North Olmsted was 13-of-40 field goal shooting. Falls ended hitting 31 of 57 from the field (54.4 percent).

The final score represented the largest lead of the game for the Bulldogs.

NORTH OLMSTED (33): Jon Dillinger 0-0-0, Brian Kissel 0-0-0, Chris Hibinger 3-2-9, Jason Mahon 1-0-2, Matt Rogalski 2-2-5, Brian Gravel 1-0-2, Zach Pattek 1-1-3, Sean Troha 0-1-1, Jim Herold 4-0-8, Shane Hurst 0-0-0, Kevin Callahan 0-0-0, Joe Valpou 1-0-2 Totals 13-6-33.

OLMSTED FALLS (77): Mickey Mental 1-0-3, Dan Binggeli 9-1-19, Pat Braddock 1-1-3, Jamar Scales 6-2-14, Steve Gansey 6-2-17, Jack DeHippo 1-2-4, Clayton Lawrence 2-1-5, Eric Arcus 0-0-1, Corey Sparks 3-0-8, Adam Rodolph 0-1-1, Jason Taber 1-0-3, Corey Emmerse 0-0-0, Greg Rantz 0-0-0, Tyler Sparks 1-0-2 Totals 31-10-77.

North Olmsted 5 15 8 5 — 33
Olmsted Falls 19 21 22 15 — 77

Three-point goals: North Olmsted 1 (Hibinger), Olmsted Falls 5 (Gansey 3, Mental 1, Taber). Rebounds: North Olmsted 22 (Mahon 6), Olmsted Falls 23 (Gansey 4). Turnovers: North Olmsted 25, Olmsted Falls 12. Total fouls: North Olmsted 15, Olmsted Falls 14. Fouled out: None. Junior varsity: Olmsted Falls 74-53.

BOYS BASKETBALL

DiFranco paces Middies to first win

Hans Schneider
The Chronicle-Telegram

SHEFFIELD LAKE — "Yeah!" With arms raised and a cry of victory, Midview senior David DiFranco walked off the court with 26 points and 14 rebounds, both game-highs.



DiFranco

For the first time this season, DiFranco and his teammates felt the thrill of victory after nine games of defeat.

Midview's 62-46 win over LCC rival Brookside was a team effort, highlighted by a dominating performance from DiFranco.

Although Midview never trailed, Brookside did make a couple of runs. The Middies jumped to a 9-0 lead before Mike Mastroianni put Brookside on the board with a three-point play. From that point,

the Cardinals outscored the Middies 9-6 the remainder of the first quarter.

And that was enough to wake the sleeping giant. DiFranco, who scored six points in the first quarter, including the last four, put his team on his back in the second.

The 6-foot-4 forward scored the first five points of the quarter to put Midview ahead 20-12.

Steve Grife's basket stopped Midview's run and teammate Cory O'Keefe hit a 3-pointer to pull within 20-17.

DiFranco again answered the challenge, scoring six of the next eight Midview points to extend the lead to double digits at 28-17. Both teams matched baskets the rest of the half and Midview took a 32-21 lead into the locker room.

But, the best was yet to come for Midview.

The Middies opened the third quarter with an 11-0 run that put the game away. Six Midview players scored in the quarter as they held the Cardinals to just four points, all from Grife.

With a 52-25 advantage entering the fourth, Midview coach Troy DiFranco was able to breathe a little easier.

"Finally, what a relief," said DiFranco. "And a great team performance. We started strong and finally had a good defensive game. The opening four minutes of the third quarter was the best defense we have played all year. Everyone contributed to this win and I am proud of them."

"This losing streak has been miserable, but these kids never quit and now they can enjoy this a little bit."

Standing out in the pivotal second and third quarters was DiFranco.

He was 4-of-4 from the field and 8-of-11 from the field in those two quarters. When he left in the fourth, his fourteen rebounds were one more than the Cardinals had.

"This feels great," he said. "We have been working at this for a long time. We were hungry for this win and we wanted to do whatever it took for us to get this win tonight. This team has a great resolve and we will not back down from any challenges."

For the Cardinals it was too much DiFranco and not enough team play.

"Obviously we had some match-up problems on the inside against DiFranco," said Brookside coach Joe Schill. "We let him alter our shots and take away our aggressiveness. We were completely out of our game."

"Playing as five individuals instead of one strong team is not going to get the job done."

Both teams return to action on Friday, with Midview (1-9, 1-3 LCC) hosting Oberlin and Brookside (1-6, 0-4 LCC) on the road against Keystone.

MIDVIEW (62): DiFranco 8-10-26, White 3-1-7, Eichenlaub 2-1-5, Reith 1-3-5, Smith 2-1-5, Bales 2-0-4, Helmick 2-0-4, Bohl 1-1-3, Ross 0-1-1, Rotuno 0-1-1, Schmidt 0-1-1 Totals 21-20-52.

BROOKSIDE (46): Grife 6-1-13, Baker 3-0-6, Fraam 2-2-6, Mastroianni 2-1-6, Zagorsky 1-0-6, O'Keefe 2-0-5, Diaz 1-0-2, Podgorski 1-0-2 Totals 20-4-46.

Midview 15 17 20 10 — 62
Brookside 12 9 4 21 — 46

Field Goals: Midview 21-33, Brookside 20-37. Free Throws: Midview 20-38, Brookside 4-6. Three-pointers: Brookside 2-7 (O'Keefe, Mastroianni). Midview 0-1. Rebounds: Midview 28 (DiFranco 14), Brookside 19 (Grife 6). Turnovers: Brookside 18, Midview 17. Fouls: Brookside 27, Midview 16. Fouled out: Brookside 3 (Baker, Fraam, Mastroianni). Technicals: Brookside 3 (Grife, Fraam, Mastroianni).

Junior Varsity: Midview, 54-35.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Royals win big behind Flannery

UNIVERSITY HEIGHTS — Court Flannery's game-high 24 points, including three 3-pointers, led three Lake Ridge (4-3) players in double figures in the Royals' 93-69 win.

Asad Butt (23) and Sam Maczuzak (15) joined Flannery in double figures for Lake Ridge, while Michael Gottesman's 23 led Fuchs Mizrahi.

Lake Ridge 20 22 28 30 — 93

Fuchs Mizrahi 14 24 13 18 — 69

Three-pointers: (LR) Flannery 3, Gottesman 4, Farhat, Bucher; (FM) Flannery 3, Maczuzak 4, Smith 3, G. Katz.

Maple Heights 51, Admiral King 50

LORAIN — Dan Biber's game-high 19 points weren't

quite enough for the Admirals (3-5), who couldn't hold a two-point lead that they had after three quarters.

Maple Heights (51): X. Suggs 3-0-8, Pitts 3-0-7, Campbell 1-0-2, Gambrell 1-3-3, Quinn 4-2-10, Bolding 4-19, Evans 5-0-10 Totals 21-6-51.

Admiral King (50): Powell 2-0-4, Nicotri 4-0-9, Newton 2-0-4, T. Suggs 3-0-8, Prikerton 1-2-4, Simmons 1-0-2, Biber 9-1-19 Totals 22-4-50.

Maple Heights 12 14 9 16 — 51
Admiral King 9 22 23 — 50

Three-pointers: (MH) X. Suggs 2, Pitts; (AK) Nicotri, T. Suggs.

Junior varsity: Maple Heights, 57-50.

Lutheran West 79, Richmond Heights 60

ROCKY RIVER — Richard Semrau made 15 of 19 field goal attempts for 30 points, had 15 rebounds and five blocked shots to lead the Longhorns (4-3, 2-2 MAC-8).

Steve Argento aided the Lutheran West cause with 12 points, 10 rebounds and five assists.

RICHMOND HEIGHTS (60): D. Davis 3-2-9, Garrett 1-0-2, B. Davis 1-0-3, Davis 3-1-6, Brown 5-2-12, Braden 5-0-10, Gardner 5-0-10, Caldwell 1-2-4, Pitts 1-0-2 Totals 25-7-50.

LUTHERAN WEST (79): Blackburn 1-0-3, Dwyer 1-6-8, Davis 2-0-4, Gray 3-1-7, Argento 6-0-12, Bailey 2-0-5, Kelly 2-0-4, Semrau 15-0-30, Hinz 2-0-4, Sprick 1-0-2 Totals 35-7-75.

Richmond Heights 4 18 18 20 — 60

Lutheran West 20 21 18 20 — 79

Three-pointers: (RH) D. Davis, B. Davis, Davis; (LW) Blackburn, Bailey.

Junior varsity: Lutheran West, 71-20.

Brooklyn 81, Columbia 54

COLUMBIA STATION — The Hurricanes had seven 3-pointers and four double-digit scorers as they overwhelmed Columbia.

Rich Gentry had 14 points to lead the Raiders (2-5, 1-3 MAC-8).

BROOKLYN (81): Lattner 5-0-14, Grassi 4-3-11, Nagelski 2-0-5, Neale 8-1-18, Akers 0-2-2, Pellicci 5-0-12, Samczak 2-0-4, Flaherty 0-1-1, Semrau 3-0-6, Neale 3-0-7, Hubbell 0-1-1 Totals 38-8-81.

COLUMBIA (54): Gentry 3-0-7, Erlone 3-1-8, Semrau 3-0-6, Mehan 6-1-14, Brooks 1-3-5,

Gebeck 1-0-2, Solones 3-2-8, Fosmark 2-0-4 Totals 22-7-54.

Brooklyn 14 23 24 20 — 81

Columbia 12 16 15 11 — 54

Three-pointers: (B) Lattner 2, Nagelski, Neale, Pellicci 2, Neale; (C) Mehan, Erlone, Gentry.

Junior varsity: Columbia, 26-15.

Bay 79, Avon Lake 51

BAY VILLAGE — Derek Riedel's 22 points led the Rockets, who evened their SWC record at 2-2.

Marc Houlas and Grant Bordine contributed 17 and 14 points, respectively, for Bay (5-3), while Max Schmidt paced the Shoremen (1-7, 0-3 SWC) with 16.

AVON LAKE (51): Schmidt 7-1-16, Riedel 9-4-4, Kragan 1-4-6, Mooradian 2-1-5, Meers 1-2-4, Skiffis 2-2-6, Bruce 2-0-5, Toric 1-0-2, Gaydon 1-0-2 Totals 17-14-51.

BAY (79): Houlass 17-4-4, Houlass 7-1-17, Doyle 3-0-12, Patzner 2-0-4, Bordine 7-0-14, Riedel 9-4-22, Truza 3-2-8, Barron 1-1-3 Totals 30-12-79.

Avon Lake 24 24 27 4 — 81
Bay 12 16 15 11 — 79

BOYS BASKETBALL

Comets control Demons

John McDermott
The Chronicle-Telegram

WESTLAKE — Practice may not always make perfect, but if Amherst coach Mitch Gillam has anything to say about it, the way the Comets have been practicing lately will get a whole lot closer to it.

Benefiting from a solid defensive performance in the second quarter, Amherst was able to survive a late scare from host Westlake on Tuesday, posting a 64-58 win in Southwestern Conference play.

With the win, the Comets improved to 3-1 in the SWC and 6-1 overall. Westlake slipped to 2-2 in the league and 3-6 on the season.

"What you saw tonight was a result of a nonchalant attitude at practice that we've been having lately," said Gillam. "You reproduce what you do on the practice floor, and tonight we had one good quarter and a couple of bad ones."

Westlake was playing without the services of several key players, including their leading scorer, top rebounder and starting point guard — all sidelined for the first of a four-game suspension for breaking team rules.

The way the Demons broke out of the gate, though, you would never have known.

Sparked by juniors Brett Henderson, Steve Turk and Alex Buskey, Westlake jumped out by five points, 11-6, at the end of the first quarter, and opened the lead to 18-10 with 6:22 to play in the half.

The Comets answered, closing out the second period with a 21-5 run, highlighted by senior guard Antonio DeJesus, who tossed in 15 of his game-high 27 points.

"We played a really good second quarter," Gillam said. "We had good pressure defense and good back pressure. Everything about our defense in that quarter was good."

Senior forward Kurt Williams, who returned to the Westlake lineup for the first time in over a week following an injury, pulled his team back in the third quarter. Nailing a 3-pointer to go along with a pair of inside shots, Williams and the Demons were able to tie the game at 39 heading into the final eight minutes.

After Westlake cut the Comets' lead to 58-54, DeJesus and senior Ryan Nowicki put the game away for Amherst from there, hitting 5-of-6 free throws down the stretch.

Amherst (64): DeJesus 6-14-27, Gonzales 6-2-14, Nowicki 5-3-13, Carter 2-0-4, Knoll 2-0-4, Odele 0-2-2 Totals 21-21-64.

Westlake (58): Henderson 7-3-18, Williams 5-1-15, Turk 5-1-12, Buskey 4-0-8, Stricker 1-2-4 Totals 23-7-58.

Amherst 6 25 8 25 — 64
Westlake 11 12 18 19 — 58

Three-pointers: Amherst 4 (DeJesus), Westlake 5 (Williams 2, Buskey, Turk, Henderson).

Junior varsity: Westlake, 57-29.

GIRLS BASKETBALL

Sabres get first win

ELYRIA — Ashley Rader's game-high 16 points led First Baptist (1-9) to a 32-24 victory over Christian Community.

CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY (24): Doane 5-1-11, Krash 0-1-14, Shaw 1-0-2, B. Shaw 4-1-10, Hughes 0-0-0 Totals 10-3-24.

FIRST BAPTIST (32): Rader 8-0-16, Bucher 2-0-4, Homer 3-0-6, Brown 1-0-2, Branger 2-0-4 Totals 16-3-32.

Christian Comm. 8 3 8 5 — 24
First Baptist 15 8 6 10 — 32

Three-pointers: (CC) B. Shaw.

Cornerstone Christian 46, Lake Ridge 32

NORTH RIDGEVILLE — Jackie Hurst's game-high 16 points led three Cornerstone (5-4) girls in double figures. Morgan Francis led the Royals (4-6) with 14 points.

CORNERSTONE CHRISTIAN (46): Pakovic 7-0-14, Adams 1-0-2, Spitalo 1-0-2, Hurst 5-6-16, Powell 5-2-12, Shaw 1-0-2, B. Shaw 4-1-10, Hughes 0-0-0 Totals 10-3-24.

LAKE RIDGE (32): D'Ono 3-1-7, Vozzolesi 1-0-2, Lerner 2-3-7, Francis 7-0-14, O'Grady 1-0-2 Totals 14-4-32.

Cornerstone C.S. 16 8 14 10 — 46
Lake Ridge 4 7 10 11 — 32